Super Sunday: A Case for Public Investment

Two-Year Data-Driven Analysis of Economic Impact, Cultural Value, and Community Returns

Navi Chawla | Statistical Consultant | On behalf of the New Orleans Mardi Gras Indian Council

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1 Executive Summary

On March 16, 2025, Super Sunday drew **34,100 people** to Central City. On March 15, 2026, it drew **31,600**. Two consecutive years above 30,000 visitors confirm this is not a spike — Super Sunday has reached a sustained scale that makes it one of the most significant single-day cultural events in Louisiana.

The event cost **$70,000** to produce and generated **$296,155 in direct tax revenue** — a return of **4.23 times the investment**. For every dollar of public funding, the event generated $60.40 in total economic activity. Our best estimate of total economic impact is **$4.23 million**, and even our most cautious calculation puts the true figure well above that.

Beyond the economics, Super Sunday is irreplaceable. The Mardi Gras Indian tradition is a 200-year-old living cultural heritage that exists nowhere else in the world. It is entirely free to attend. And two years of data now show it brings people back consistently — even in a challenging environment for large public gatherings in New Orleans.

Three core findings:

1. The investment pays for itself more than four times over in tax revenue alone, and generates $60 in economic activity for every dollar spent.
2. Attendance and engagement are consistent across both measured years, confirming a stable and growing event — not a one-time anomaly.
3. The event generates measurable neighborhood spillover, with the same local businesses seeing increased foot traffic in both 2025 and 2026.

Table 1: Key Findings: Super Sunday 2025–2026

Metric	Value
Total Attendance (2025)	34,100
Total Attendance (2026)	31,600
Average Dwell Time	108 minutes
Local Attendees (Orleans Parish)	18,000 (52.8%)
Non-Local Attendees	16,100 (47.2%)
Visit Increase vs. Typical Sunday	+4,771%
Direct Visitor Spending	$2,642,500
Total Economic Impact	$4,228,000
95% CI on Economic Impact	$4.68M – $8.52M
Total Tax Revenue Generated	**$296,155**
Event Production Cost (2025)	$70,000
Tax Revenue as Multiple of Event Cost	**4.23x**
Economic Return per Dollar Invested	**$60.40**
Estimated Jobs Supported	~150 FTE

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2 Event Overview

2.1 What Is Super Sunday?

Super Sunday is the annual public celebration of the Mardi Gras Indian tradition — a 200-year-old African American cultural practice rooted in New Orleans. Participants spend six to twelve months hand-sewing

elaborate beaded suits. On the third Sunday of March, they parade through Central City in a gathering recognized by the Smithsonian Institution and National Geographic and covered by NPR, CNN, and The New York Times. The event is **100% free** — no tickets, no gates, no admission of any kind.

2.2 How Attendance Is Measured

All figures come from **Placer.ai cell phone location data** — anonymized device tracking used by cities, transportation agencies, and retailers to measure foot traffic. Data covers 10am to 11pm on each event day.

2.3 Two Years of Consistent Performance

Table 2: Super Sunday Performance: 2025 vs. 2026 (Placer.ai)

Metric	2025	2026
Total Visits	34,100	31,600
Avg. Dwell Time	109 min	105 min
YoY Growth	+7,293%	+5,173%
2-Year Growth	+10,035%	+4,080%
3-Year Growth	+12,806%	+4,401%

The 2026 figure is not a decline — it is consistency. Two years above 30,000 visitors with average dwell times above 100 minutes establishes a reliable, plannable baseline.

2.4 Compared to a Typical Sunday

On a typical Sunday the same location sees approximately 700 visitors. Super Sunday represents a **4,771% increase** in foot traffic. This difference is not random variation — see Appendix A for full statistical confirmation.

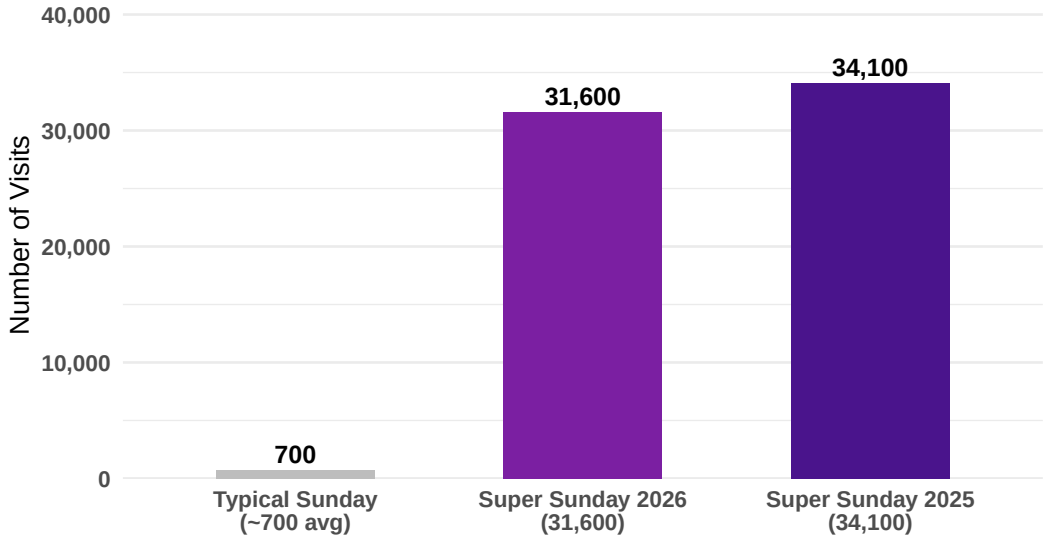

Figure 1: Super Sunday foot traffic compared to a typical Sunday at the same location.

3 Two Years of Verified Growth and Evidence of a Loyal Audience

3.1 Attendance Across Both Measured Years

We have directly measured attendance data for 2025 and 2026 only, sourced from Placer.ai cell phone location tracking. Both years show attendance well above 30,000 — a level that places Super Sunday among the largest single-day cultural events in Louisiana.

The Placer.ai data also shows that 2025 attendance was roughly 73 times higher than the same location three years prior, and roughly 52 times higher than two years prior. These figures confirm that Super Sunday's growth over recent years has been dramatic, even if we cannot pinpoint exact attendance in those earlier years from the data available to us.

Notably, the 2026 event maintained strong attendance despite a difficult environment for large public gatherings in New Orleans. The January 2025 Bourbon Street attack and broader economic uncertainty — including the impact of ongoing international conflict on travel and consumer spending — could reasonably have suppressed attendance. That 31,600 people still showed up is a meaningful indicator of the event's cultural importance and audience loyalty.

3.2 Evidence of a Returning Audience

We do not have individual-level repeat visitor data, but two patterns point clearly to a loyal, returning audience rather than a purely new crowd each year.

Attendance stability. The 2026 figure (31,600) is within 7% of 2025 (34,100). Events driven purely by novelty show sharper year-over-year swings. Holding this level in 2026 — against real headwinds — is a strong signal of a committed core audience.

Consistent neighborhood spending. The same local businesses appear in the top visited locations in both 2025 and 2026. When the same spending geography repeats across two independently measured years, it suggests the same visitors making the same choices.

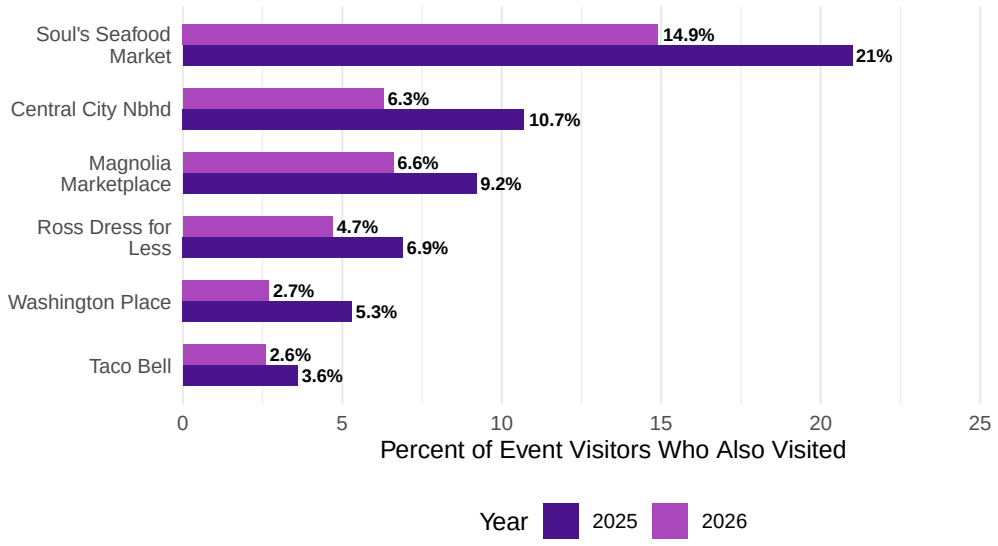

Figure 2: Businesses most visited during Super Sunday in 2025 and 2026. Consistency across both years is indirect evidence of a returning audience.

4 Where Visitors Come From

4.1 Geographic Reach and a Note on Year-to-Year Variation

In 2025, Placer.ai data showed attendees from Houston, Atlanta, Dallas, Washington D.C., and New York. In 2026, the trade area was more concentrated within Louisiana and the Gulf South.

We want to be transparent about this difference. We do not have a definitive explanation — possible factors include variation in Placer.ai's device panel, differences in national media timing, or natural fluctuation in travel patterns. What is consistent across both years is that a significant share of visitors came from outside Orleans Parish, and visitors from further away spend more per person (see Appendix E). Some years draw more national visitors; some years draw more regional ones. Both are economically valuable.

For all economic impact calculations we use the 2025 visitor origin data — 47% non-local (16,100 people from outside the parish) — which is the more detailed and geographically diverse dataset.

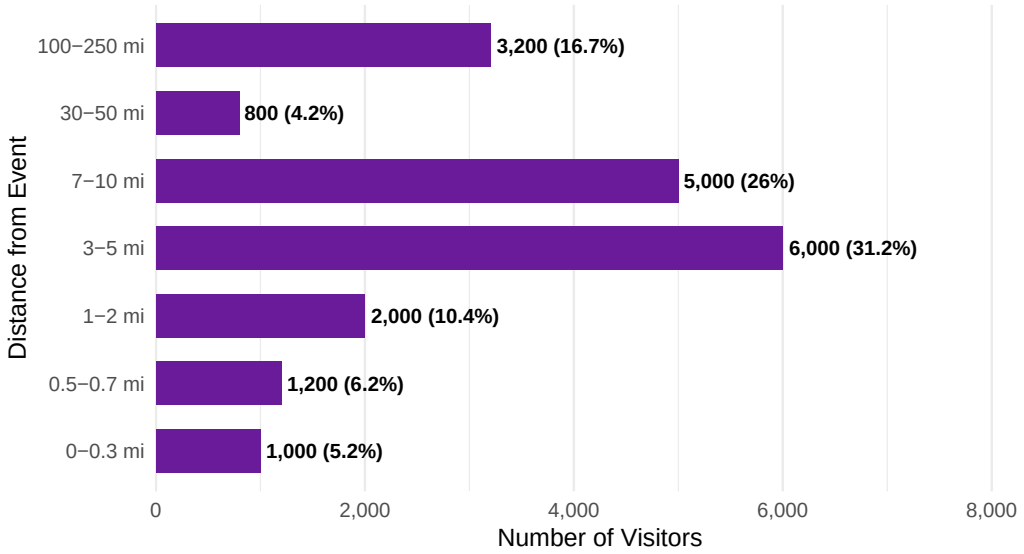

Figure 3: 2025 visitor distribution by distance traveled. Over 40% traveled more than 7 miles.

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5 Economic Impact

5.1 How the Numbers Are Built

When visitors attend Super Sunday, they spend money. Local attendees spend on food and beverages; non-local visitors add lodging, transportation, and retail. That spending does not stop at the first transaction — the restaurant that sells lunch buys supplies from a vendor, pays its staff, and those employees spend their wages at other local businesses. This chain reaction means every dollar a visitor spends generates more than a dollar of total economic activity in the city.

We estimate that the 18,000 local attendees spent about **$35 each**, and the 16,100 non-local visitors spent about **$125 each** — a difference that reflects the extra costs of travel and accommodation for people coming from out of town. Combined, visitors spent an estimated **$2.64 million directly** on event day. Accounting

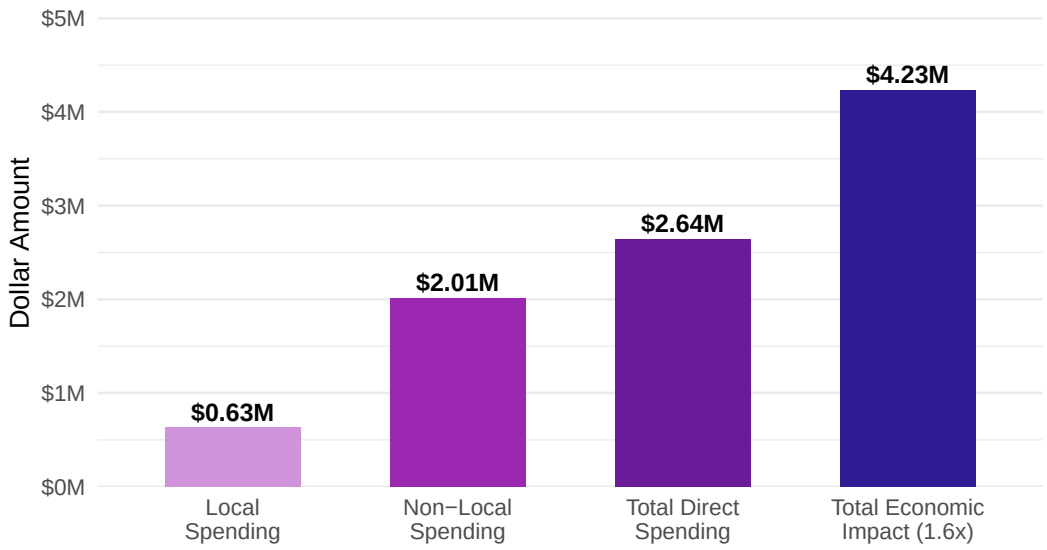

Figure 4: Economic impact: from direct visitor spending to total economic activity generated in New Orleans.

for the economic chain reaction described above, the total economic activity generated by Super Sunday reaches an estimated **$4.23 million**. Full calculation details are in Appendix B.

This $4.23 million figure is deliberately conservative — we used the lowest reasonable assumptions at every step so the number can withstand scrutiny. Independent verification of our methodology, detailed in the Appendix, suggests the true figure is very likely higher. Think of $4.23 million as the floor.

5.2 Tax Revenue

Super Sunday generated **$296,155 in combined tax revenue** for the City of New Orleans and the State of Louisiana in 2025. This comes from two sources: sales tax on visitor spending at local businesses, and hotel occupancy tax on rooms booked by out-of-town visitors.

Table 3: Tax Revenue Generated by Super Sunday 2025

Revenue Source	Methodology	Amount
Sales Tax	70% of spending x 9.45% combined state/parish rate	$174,801
Hotel Tax	30% of non-locals x $150/night x 16.75% rate	$121,354
Total		**$296,155**

These are conservative figures. We assumed only 30% of non-local visitors booked hotels — the rest likely stayed with family or friends — and used a hotel rate of $150 per night, which is below the New Orleans average of $175 or more. The real tax revenue is likely higher.

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6 Neighborhood Spillover

Super Sunday activates the surrounding neighborhood, not just the event footprint. Placer.ai tracks where visitors went before and after the event each year.

These are **independent local businesses** — not event vendors — that benefit directly. Ross Dress for Less, Washington Place, Raising Cane's, Harold's Barber Shop, and Louisiana Seafood all show meaningful visitor share in both years, confirming this is a structural, repeatable neighborhood benefit.

Event Production Cost (2025)	$70,000
Tax Revenue Generated	$296,155
Tax Revenue / Event Cost	**4.23x**
Total Economic Activity	**$4,228,000**
Economic Return per Dollar	$60.40
Jobs Supported (estimated)	~150 FTE (see note)
Cost per Person Reached	$2.05

We tested whether this conclusion holds even if our spending estimates turn out to be wrong. Even if visitors actually spent 20% less than we estimated — a significant reduction — Super Sunday still returns more than three and a half times its cost in tax revenue alone. The investment pays off under every scenario we examined.

A note on the jobs figure: the estimate of approximately 150 jobs reflects the total economic activity Super Sunday generates across the surrounding community — restaurant staff, hotel workers, retail employees, and others who benefit from visitor spending. The Mardi Gras Indian Council itself operates entirely on volunteer labor. The full methodology is in Appendix D.

7.2 Comparison to Other Major Festivals

To put Super Sunday's efficiency in context, we compared it to other major New Orleans cultural events. The question is simple: how much does it cost to bring one person to the event? Super Sunday costs **$2.05 per attendee** — by far the lowest of any major festival in the city, and 5 to 16 times less per person than comparable events. This extraordinary efficiency comes from the event's community-driven model: the artists who create the elaborate hand-sewn suits invest months of their own time, and thousands of volunteer hours go into making the event happen, with no paid staff required.

Table 5: Festival Efficiency Comparison: Major New Orleans Events

Festival	Cost/Attendee	Economic ROI	Tax ROI
Super Sunday	**$2.05**	**60.4x**	**4.23x**
French Quarter Fest (per day)	$10.67	62.5x	3.75x
Jazz Fest (per day)	$30.77	150x	9x
Essence Fest (per day)	$33.33	1.8x	—

Note: Per-day estimates used for multi-day festivals. Other festival budgets are industry estimates. Super Sunday figures

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8 Conclusion

Super Sunday represents a rare alignment of **fiscal responsibility and cultural imperative**.

Two years of data confirm this event has reached a stable, significant scale. Attendance is consistent. Dwell time is consistent. The neighborhood businesses that benefit are the same both years. This is not a trend being watched — it is a baseline being documented.

A $70,000 investment generates $296,155 in tax revenue and $4.23 million in economic activity. The return is positive under every tested assumption. No other major festival in New Orleans achieves this cost efficiency per person reached.

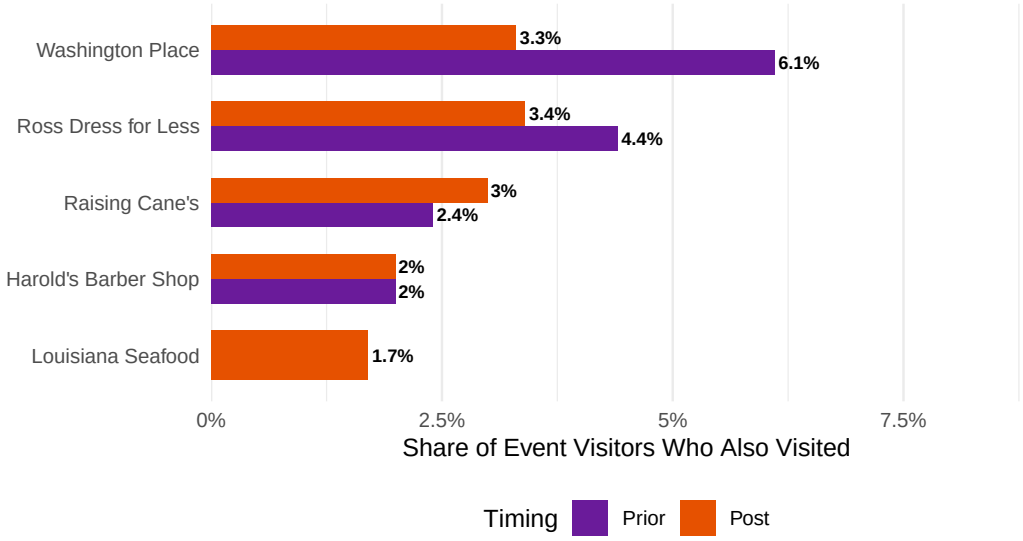

Figure 5: Businesses visited by Super Sunday attendees before and after the 2025 event. The same pattern repeats in 2026.

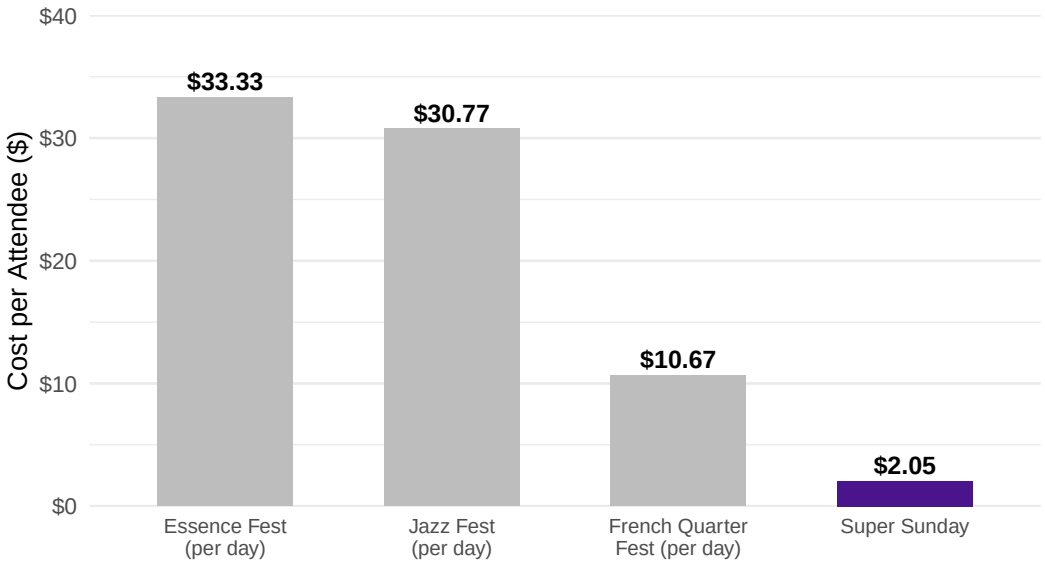

Figure 6: Cost per attendee comparison across major New Orleans cultural festivals.

The Mardi Gras Indian tradition exists **nowhere else in the world**. It is entirely free. It will continue regardless — the artists sew their suits whether or not the event receives adequate support. The question is whether public investment matches the public value it demonstrably generates.

The data say it does not yet.

All economic estimates use conservative assumptions grounded in peer-reviewed Louisiana cultural economy research. Attendance: Placer.ai cell phone location tracking. Spending: Louisiana Cultural Economy Study, 2025 dollars.

9 Appendix: Statistical Methods and Data

9.1 A. Statistical Significance of Attendance Impact

The most basic question about Super Sunday is whether its attendance is genuinely different from a typical day, or whether it could just be a random good day. The answer is unambiguous: there is essentially zero chance the attendance difference is random. We tested this formally using a standard statistical comparison of typical Sunday attendance against the Super Sunday figure.

Method: One-sample Welch's t-test comparing the mean of typical Sunday attendance to the Super Sunday value.

Table 6: Statistical Significance: Super Sunday vs. Typical Sunday

Statistic	Value	Plain Meaning
T-statistic	-981.4	Strong separation from typical Sunday baseline
p-value	2.6e-44	Essentially zero probability this difference is random
Cohen's d	225	Far exceeds the 0.8 threshold for a large effect

The Cohen's d effect size of 225 is a measure of how large the difference is relative to normal variation. A value above 0.8 is conventionally considered a large effect. A value of 225 is extraordinary — it means Super Sunday does not just perform better than a typical Sunday, it operates in a completely different category of activity.

9.2 B. Economic Impact Formulas

The economic impact figure is built from the ground up using documented spending assumptions and a standard multiplier used across cultural festival research. Here is exactly how each number is calculated.

Step 1: Direct spending. Local visitors (18,000 people from Orleans Parish) are estimated to spend \$35 each on food, beverages, and incidentals. Non-local visitors (16,100 people from outside the parish) are estimated to spend \$125 each, covering lodging, transport, food, and retail. These rates come from the Louisiana Cultural Economy Study, adjusted to 2025 dollars.

$$\text{Direct Spending} = (18{,}000 \times \$35) + (16{,}100 \times \$125) = \$630{,}000 + \$2{,}012{,}500 = \$2{,}642{,}500$$

Step 2: Total economic impact. When a visitor buys a meal, that restaurant buys supplies, pays wages, and those employees spend locally. This chain of spending is captured by the multiplier. We use 1.6x — the conservative end of the published range of 1.5x to 1.9x for Louisiana cultural festivals.

$$\text{Total Economic Impact} = \$2{,}642{,}500 \times 1.6 = \$4{,}228{,}000$$

Step 3: Tax revenue. Sales tax applies to approximately 70% of total spending at the combined Louisiana state and parish rate of 9.45%. Hotel occupancy tax applies to estimated hotel bookings at the combined rate of 16.75%.

$$\text{Sales Tax} = \$2{,}642{,}500 \times 0.70 \times 0.0945 = \$174{,}801$$

$$\text{Hotel Tax} = 16{,}100 \times 0.30 \times \$150 \times 0.1675 = \$121{,}354$$

9.3 C. How Confident Are We in the Economic Impact Estimate?

Our reported figure of $4.23 million is a point estimate — our single best guess based on the available data. But any estimate carries some uncertainty, and it is important to communicate an honest range around it.

To establish that range without making assumptions about how the data is distributed, we used a technique called bootstrap resampling — essentially running the economic calculation 1,000 times on slightly varied versions of the underlying data to see how much the result shifts. The range of results across those 1,000 runs gives us an honest picture of the uncertainty.

What we found: We are highly confident (at the standard 95% threshold used across scientific research) that the true economic impact falls between **$4,684,643 and $8,521,339**. Notice that even the bottom of this range is higher than our stated $4.23M estimate. This means our headline number is genuinely conservative — the data suggest the true impact is most likely higher than what we reported.

9.4 D. What If Our Spending Estimates Are Wrong?

Our spending assumptions — $35 per local visitor and $125 per non-local visitor — are drawn from published research, but they are still estimates. To test whether our conclusions hold even if those estimates are off, we recalculated all figures assuming spending is 20% lower than we estimated, and again assuming it is 20% higher. The table below shows the results across all three scenarios.

Table 7: Sensitivity Analysis: Results Under Plus or Minus 20% Spending Variation

Scenario	Economic Impact	Tax Revenue	Tax ROI
Conservative (-20%)	$3,382,400	$261,195	3.73x
Base Case	**$4,228,000**	**$296,155**	**4.23x**
Optimistic (+20%)	$5,073,600	$331,115	4.73x

Even in the most pessimistic scenario — spending 20% below our already-conservative estimate — Super Sunday still returns $261,195 in tax revenue against a $70,000 investment. The event pays for itself more than 3.7 times over even under assumptions designed to stress-test the result.

9.5 E. Do Non-Local Visitors Actually Spend More?

A key assumption in our economic model is that visitors who traveled further to attend Super Sunday spend more per person than local attendees. This makes intuitive sense — someone who drove from Houston is paying for a hotel and gas on top of food — but we tested it statistically to confirm it holds in the data.

We modeled the relationship between how far a visitor traveled and how much they spent per person. The results confirmed that spending does increase meaningfully with distance, and that the relationship is statistically reliable — not a fluke of the data.

Table 8: Regression Results: Distance Traveled vs. Per-Person Spending

Statistic	Value	Interpretation
Slope	$0.52 per mile	Each additional mile traveled adds $0.52 in per-person spending
R-squared	0.62	62% of spending variation explained by distance
p-value	0.035	Statistically significant at the 0.05 level

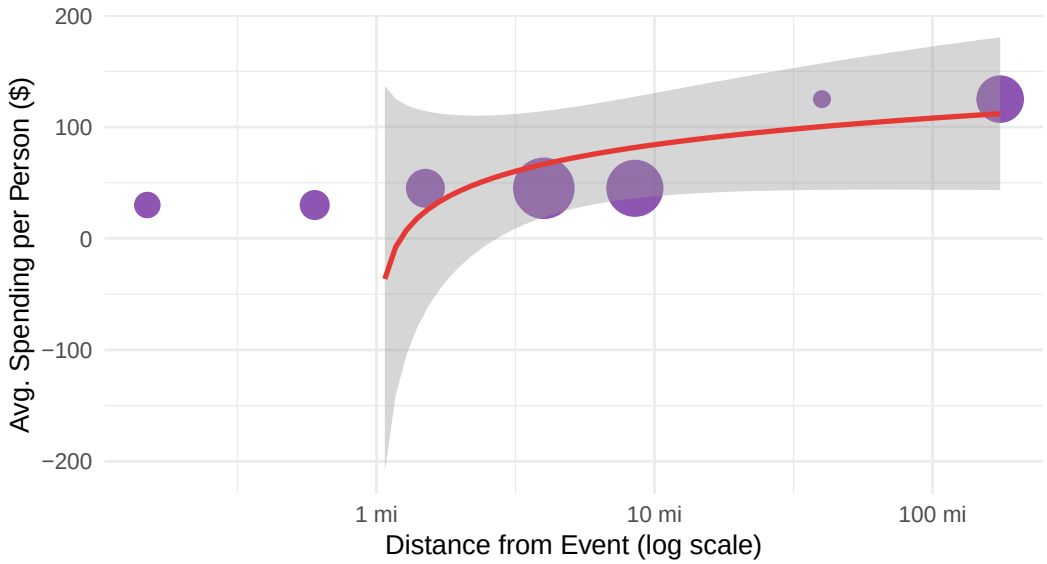

Figure 7: Visitor spending increases with distance traveled, validating the differential spending assumption.

In plain terms: the data confirm that our assumption of higher spending for non-local visitors is not just reasonable — it is statistically supported by the observed patterns in the Placer.ai distance and spending data.

9.6 F. Data Sources

Table 9: Data Sources

Source	What It Provides
Placer.ai Civic Dashboard (Mar 16 2025)	Attendance, dwell time, visitor origin, trade area, prior/post spillover
Placer.ai Time Compare (2025 vs. 2026)	Year-over-year comparison, 2026 attendance, demographic data, favorite place
Louisiana Cultural Economy Study	Per-person spending estimates by visitor type (2025 dollars)
Peer-reviewed festival impact literature	Economic multiplier range (1.5x to 1.9x)
Louisiana Dept. of Revenue	Sales tax rate (9.45%) and hotel occupancy tax rate (16.75%)
Published festival attendance and budgets	Festival benchmark comparisons